was becoming clear: ‘The roads are unsettled, and all the clans and chiefs relieved from the slight control which did exist, plunder, quarrel and fight with one another,’ wrote Fraser.

> The King’s army in Kashmir has been wholly destroyed . . . Out of 15,000 men, only 3,000 have returned. The rest have either perished, or gone over to the enemy . . . Meanwhile Shah Shooja exerts all his energies and endeavours to raise money in every possible manner, cheers some, coaxes others, and secures the rest by promises. He intrigues too with the sardars [commanders] of the other party, and makes every sacrifice and does everything that a brave man, and an anxious king can do, with an empty treasury, a defeated, dispersed army, and proud independent nobles.[54]

In desperation, the Shah recruited a new army from the tribes of the Khyber, and spent May drilling whatever recruits he could afford to raise; a few more troops continued to straggle in from Kashmir ‘dismounted, disarmed and almost naked’.[55] Such was the tension in Peshawar that an angry mob gathered outside the Embassy’s quarters after a rumour spread that the British had been in communication with the rebels and that Shuja had ordered the house to be plundered.[56] On 12 June, with the safety of the Embassy now in jeopardy, and the roads becoming daily more dangerous, Elphinstone and his assistants said farewell to the Shah, and headed off south-east towards Delhi and Calcutta.

Shuja meanwhile prepared to make his stand. ‘Though the Shah was engulfed with catastrophic news from everywhere and helplessly watched malevolence and ill-fate taking over his administration, he stood steadfast and didn’t let fear overcome him,’ recorded Sultan Mahmoud Durrani in the *Tarikh-i-Sultani*. ‘Instead he marched off to resist Shah Mahmoud’s attack.’[57]

Less than a week later, the British were camped on the left bank of the Indus, under the sheltering walls of Akbar’s great fort at Attock, when they saw a bedraggled royal caravan arrive on the north bank and hastily prepare to make the crossing. It was the blind Shah Zaman and Wa’fa Begum, leading the Sadozai harem to safety. ‘To describe to you the effect of such a meeting upon the minds of all our party would be as difficult as melancholy,’ wrote Fraser. ‘Many with difficulty restrained their tears. The blinded monarch was seated on a low cot . . . His eyes at a moderate distance would not be perceived to be defective, merely as if there was a speck on each, with a little irregularity of the surface. After we were seated,